

Safe browsing

Mozilla to check Firefox add-ons in an effort to close security holes

Opera update

The final build of Opera out with added improvements such as Turbo and easy tab management

Your questions, our answers

All your computer niggles and nags are dealt with here!

Weird problem with PC going to sleep

I have a PC running an Intel Pentium 4 3.06 GHz processor, 512 MB DDR1 RAM, installed on an Intel D865GSA desktop board. A few days back, the motherboard has been going into sleep mode as told by my friend and dealer. So, I have replaced the motherboard and memory. Now, I run a Biostar G31D-M7 board. I've also had to replace my 512 MB DDR1 RAM with a 1 GB stick of DDR2 RAM.

I've installed Windows Vista Ultimate on my machine. When I was using my machine with the old configuration, it didn't support Windows Aero, but now it is working rather well. Now the problem that I'm facing is that sometimes my system doesn't start properly and it hangs during start-up. If I restart it by pressing reset button, it doesn't respond and locks up again at start-up. I have to leave it idle for some time. After that, it starts properly otherwise I have to repair my operating system using the installation DVD. The same problem occurs when I play a game like Virtua Cop. After playing a while, the PC shuts down automatically and then, suddenly, the start-up problem occurs again.

I want to know why these start-up problems are occurring over and over again. What is the solution for this and what is this problem of board going into sleep mode? I also want to use Windows XP within Vista through VMware. Will my machine allow me to do so?

S.D. Sharma

 The problem you're facing could be because of a poor power supply. If you haven't reinstalled Windows, then maybe the older drivers are causing some problems. Try a fresh install and download the latest drivers from the internet.

I hope your power supply is perfectly fine. If it's more than a couple of years old, you should try using a different power supply from a friend to see if that's the problem. Also, check for loose connections - RAM and power cables specifically.

If nothing works, it could be a bug in the motherboard which can be fixed by a BIOS update. Look up for the manufacturer's site for a list of bug fixes. Be extremely careful if you go ahead with flashing the BIOS. You can damage the board.

1 GB of memory is a little too less for Windows XP to run within VMware. It's worth trying but another GB of memory would definitely help

Laptop display problems

Some two to three days back, I noticed a slight problem with my laptop's LCD. Just at the bottom of the screen, near the taskbar where the shortcut icons and time are generally displayed, I could see a thin line blinking across the LCD. It frequently went on and off and then remained for seconds. Could you please tell me what it is and how to rectify this problem?

My system configuration is: HP Commercial 6530s, Intel Core 2 Duo CPU T5870 2 GHz, Windows Vista Home Premium, 3 GB RAM. I am far away from the service centre.

Noklam Bisai
Arunachal Pradesh

 Try opening up an image in full screen or play a movie at full screen. See if that line keeps flashing and showing up

even then. If it does, it could be a problem with the LCD display. Otherwise, it could be a resolution problem. Try reinstalling the graphics drivers. If nothing works, you have no other choice but to take it to your local service centre to get it fixed.

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Bad sectors on hard disk drive

I have an Intel Core 2 Duo PC with a 320 GB hard drive and 2 GB RAM. My hard disk has developed bad sectors on it. I want to know whether this is bad for my drive. Can these sectors be fixed or not? What is a bad sector? What does it mean and what causes them to occur?

Pawan Maurya

 A bad sector is a small portion on the hard disk that has suffered some damage and is therefore unusable. The bad sectors will not cause you harm in day to day operation. The scandisk utility marks the bad sectors so that the operating system skips them and no data is written there. As for causes - it can be physical damage during the manufacturing process itself or wear and tear or just faults that show up randomly.

You can try fixing the problem by right-clicking on the hard drive with bad sectors in Windows Explorer. Click on Properties and click the Tools tab. Under error checking, click "Check now". Check the box

that says "Scan for and Attempt Recovery of Bad Sectors." Click on Start. If there are physical bad sectors, the only fix to give the drive for repairs or replacement.

CPU usage is always too high

My computer specifications are: Intel Core 2 Duo E8400
MSI Radeon R4850
MSI P45 Neo motherboard
800 Watt PSU

My PC is taking too much time to boot. When I play FIFA 09, the game lags and the CPU temperature rises to 65C. The CPU usage is also too high at some 50 to 56 per cent when there's nothing running on the PC. Is this caused by some kind of malware or virus?

Shreyan Mohapatra

 Yes, it could be malware. In the task manager, look at what application is using the most CPU resources. Sort by overall memory consumption and also CPU utilisation. Also, look for services or applications that are taking up lots of memory. Try closing those. If that doesn't work, uninstall your motherboard and graphics card drivers and reinstall them. The last option would be to try scanning the system for malware.

Is this the right time to go in for a graphics card?

I need suggestions regarding

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